

Lifestyle inflation is not the enemy, though. When we earn more, it is reasonable to spend more. It's when the lifestyle creep is driven by comparison, wanting what others have and going after it solely because they have it and it looks good for them. Only to find it was not enough, did not bring purpose, and was not something we really valued.

Another thing that can derail our efforts toward contentment is when our accomplishments don't feel the way we thought they would.

Even debt payoff, savings, high net worth, and early retirement don't bring joy. We've seen the disillusionment on the other side of these financial milestones when people realize it's not the nirvana they were told it would be. That's not to say we shouldn't pursue these things, just don't expect these things to bring contentment, inner peace, or ultimate happiness. Once we achieve what we've been aiming at for a long time, there's certainly a rush of enthusiasm. It's exhilarating, and we feel unstoppable! But it's not long before we return to our relative baseline of operating and perceiving.

So, what's to be done?! Are we doomed to dissatisfaction? Will we never experience what it's like to have enough? Certainly not!

You can come to a place of satisfaction with what you own and do as well as with who you are and what you've done. You don't have to be a statistic that desires more for the sake of more. Your desires, goals, and actions can be tethered to your values, season, and intentionality. You can feel good about the decisions you make with your time and money. And that feeling doesn't need to be fleeting.

This is values-based spending in action.

But finding satisfaction with your stuff is just the half of it. Finding contentment with who you are and what you've done requires a deeper level of work. Reconciling the various aspects of your personhood and coming to terms with your uniqueness—the parts of yourself that you are proud of and the parts you wish you could change. So many people spend unnecessary money, time, and energy on efforts to alter their situation and circumstances without ever considering what embracing and valuing their current position might look like.

When we are drawn to give more focus to what we don't have versus what we do have, we are bound to experience discontentment. But if we are able to find beauty in our season, appreciation for the journey we've been